



A VINTAGE Ford Mustang speeds down the drag strip at Irwindale Speedway's final Thursday Night Thunder event on Dec. 5. Photographs by WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times

COLUMN ONE

Curtain falls on the fast and curious

L.A. was once ‘Drag City.’ Now the area’s last speedway is closed after final running of Thursday Night Thunder in Irwindale.

BY DANIEL MILLER

The two racers idled in their vehicles near the starting line, one behind the other, waiting for their last chance to blast down the drag strip at Irwindale Speedway. They were bound by a love for speed — but that’s about all they had in common. Craig Rayburn, 61, had competed in hundreds of events at the racetrack, and drove a 420-horsepower muscle car with a snarling V-8. Trevor Kirby, there for the first time, was strapped into a dragster with a one-cylinder motor that made about seven horsepower. And he was 9. Their trips down the 1/4-mile strip were bleating and braying symphonies, one a torchbearer for Irwindale’s past, the other embodying drag racing’s promising — but uncertain — [See *Speedway*, A10]



ROBERT ROTH changes the tires on his ice cream truck in preparation for his run on the drag strip during the final Thursday Night Thunder.

END OF AN ERA: The closure of Irwindale Speedway marks the latest blow to Southern California’s racing scene. SPORTS, D4-5

Arcadia politician at center of scandal

Questions surround Eileen Wang after her fiancé is accused of a pro-China plot.

BY REBECCA ELLIS AND HANNAH FRY

An Arcadia City Council member is the fiancée of a man charged by federal prosecutors last week with acting as an illegal agent for the Chinese government by attempting to influence local politicians, according to court records and interviews. The personal relationship between Eileen Wang, elected two years ago to the council of the San Gabriel Valley suburb, and Yaoning “Mike” Sun deepens questions around what Wang knew about an alleged plot to push pro-China policies, particularly regarding Taiwan. In the criminal complaint against Sun, prosecutors referred to a local politician, “Individual 1,” alleging that [See *Arcadia*, A7]

Disney CEO aims to stop taking sides

Bob Iger wants out of the culture wars. Walt Disney Co. and its chief executive have made a sharp pivot since doubling down on diversity and inclusion efforts in the wake of George Floyd’s murder in Minneapolis four and a half years ago. At the time, Disney’s top executives, including then-Chairman Iger, vowed in a message to employees: “We intend to keep the conversation going ... for as long as it takes to bring about real change.” The Magic Kingdom dropped its pomp greeting to fans for its nightly fireworks display. “Good evening, ladies and gentlemen, boys and girls” became a gender-neutral salutation to “dreamers of all ages.” Pixar’s animated movie, “Lightyear,” included a brief kiss between two female characters; and Disney’s animated film “Strange World” featured the company’s first biracial queer teen hero. But in the past week, Disney acknowledged that a

Bob Iger’s move is a sharp pivot after the company’s recent diversity and inclusion efforts

BY MEG JAMES



BOB IGER increasingly has stressed the importance of steering Disney away from overt political messages. JAY L. CLENDENIN Los Angeles Times

transgender athlete storyline had been removed from an upcoming Pixar animated series, “Win or Lose,” about a middle-school softball team. In a statement, Disney said it recognized “many parents would prefer to discuss certain subjects with their children on their own terms and timeline.” And Iger signed off on the settlement of a high-profile defamation lawsuit brought last spring by President-elect Donald Trump, amid howls from journalists that the owner of ABC News had caved to political pressure. Disney agreed to pay \$1 million for Trump’s legal fees and donate an additional \$15 million for his future presidential library. Trump sued ABC News and anchor George Stephanopoulos last spring after the journalist asserted during an on-air interview that a civil court jury had found Trump “liable for rape” in a case brought by advice columnist E. Jean Carroll. Instead, New York [See *Iger*, A5]

Saving a fellow dog’s life while in captivity

‘Closed colonies’ are still largest supplier of canine blood in state, despite officials’ push to phase them out.

BY MELODY GUTIERREZ AND ALENE TCHEKMEDYAN

Inside a subzero freezer at a Northern California pet hospital sit rows of carefully labeled bags of fresh frozen plasma. Each pouch could save a pet’s life: a retriever that ingested poison, a corgi with a bleeding disorder, a puppy with parvovirus. While the pouches each look the same, their straw-colored contents come from starkly different places. Some of the blood products are from dogs like Augustus, a 55-pound Belgian Malinois whose owner signed him up to donate blood at a canine community blood bank, which is modeled after the human volunteer system. Other bags hold a more controversial history. Their contents come from donor kennels in California, where hundreds of dogs and cats live in “closed colonies” as full-time blood suppliers. These captive animals have long provided a steady stream of blood to meet the state’s surging demand for advanced veterinary care. For decades, California veterinarians were required to buy blood exclusively from closed colonies in the state, a system regulators decided would ensure the products were safe and the donors free of diseases. Veterinary hospitals that collected blood in-house for their patients weren’t allowed to sell it. But in 2021, state lawmakers declared closed colonies inhumane because the animals are held captive. They vowed to replace them with community blood banks and ordered that the state’s inspection reports — long sealed — be open to public scrutiny. The law, however, included crucial caveats: Only closed colonies for dogs would be shut down, and that phaseout would begin after community blood banks — where owners volunteer their pets to give blood — consistently matched their output. After three years, they’re not even close. California’s closed colonies continue to supply the bulk of canine blood sold in the state. Without the blood supplied by captive donors, veterinarians say, many other dogs in critical need would die from injuries and disease. But this poses a dilemma for those who want to see the closed colonies shut down. The Times found that the closed colonies produced more than 97% of canine blood products — including whole blood, red blood cells and fresh frozen plasma — sold in the state through September of this year. That divide will leave California [See *Dogs*, A6]

Tipoffs preceded market attack
German authorities say the suspect has made numerous threats over the years. **WORLD, A3**

Great Highway plan causes furor
Proposal to transform San Francisco roadway into a park ignites recall effort. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Higbee returns as hero for Rams
Tight end catches the go-ahead touchdown in a 19-9 comeback win over the Jets. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather
Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 66/50. **B5**
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